CHAPTER 3

The Early Shansabanis: Firuzkuh, Bamiyan, and Tiginabad/ Old Qandahar, *c.* 1140s–1170s

In *c.* AH 539–540/1145–1146 CE, Qutb al-Din Muhammad (d. AH 543/1148 CE), 'Izz al-Din's second son (Genealogy, p. xvii), established his seat at Firuzkuh – now generally accepted to be near the village of Jam, at the confluence of the Hari Rud and Jam Rud (Figure 2.2).[1] In virtual simultaneity, the Shansabanis expanded eastward beyond Ghur to the great religious center and commercial entrepôt of Bamiyan, where Fakhr al-Din Mas'ud (r. AH 540–558/1145–1163 CE), 'Izz al-Din's eldest son, presided over an agnatic Shansabani lineage that ruled the region through the early thirteenth century. In the late 1150s, the infamous 'Ala' al-Din Husain *Jahan-suz* (r. AH 544–556/1149–1161 CE; further discussed below) departed from Firuzkuh southward and wrested Qandahar – quite possibly the medieval Tiginabad (see later in this chapter) – from his arch enemies the Yamini-Ghaznavids.[2] It was from here that, little more than a decade later in AH 568/1173 CE, the brothers Shams al-Din Muhammad and Shihab al-Din Muhammad – two of 'Izz al-Din's grandsons, and nephews of the notorious 'Ala' al-Din *Jahan-suz* – would set out to eradicate the Oghüz bands occupying Ghazna. Upon achieving this victory, Shihab al-Din was crowned Sultan Mu'izz al-Din there, thus creating a third Shansabani lineage at the once grand, erstwhile Yamini capital (cf. esp. Chapter 5).

The present chapter's focus on the late 1140s through early 1170s CE – prior to the definitive Shansabani conquest of Ghazna AH 569/1173–1174 CE – encompasses the initial phase of Jam-Firuzkuh and the early Shansabani campaigns to Bamiyan and Tiginabad/Old Qandahar. Against the background of this multi-directional expansion, the Shansabanis' architectural patronage in the successively acquired power bases is extremely varied, defying any expectations of a recognizably unified and singular imperial presence. In fact, this variety seems to belie centralized imperial expansion (cf. also Chapter 1, above).

Archaeological investigations at the site of Jam-Firuzkuh brought forth virtually no evidence of palatial architecture from the time of Shansabani occupation (1140s–*c.* 1215), despite Juzjani's mentions of large palaces and forts there. Instead, the early Firuzkuh Shansabanis seem to have concentrated on defensive and religious–civic structures (Figures 3.1–3.6; see